



Commentary on the (In)Visibility of LGBTQ+ Victims in Domestic Violence Fatality Reviews

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Abstract

Purpose This paper is a commentary on the (in)visibility of Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual, Trans and Queer (LGBTQ+) victims in Domestic Violence Fatality Reviews (DVFRs).

Methods Drawing on a practitioner–researcher perspective and a case study of Domestic Homicide Reviews (DHRs) in England and Wales, this paper’s originality stems from the author’s practitioner–researcher perspective.

Results LGBTQ+ lives can be made (in)visible as a result of how in-scope deaths are identified, whether knowledge and expertise are included, and because of how the lives of LGBTQ+ victims are represented.

Conclusion This commentary explores how DVFRs can make LGBTQ+ lives (in)visible. Critically, however, it identifies how these considerations relate to broader questions, including the responses to LGBTQ+ domestic abuse generally and the functioning of DVFRs specifically, and also has implications for how researchers use the findings of review.

Keywords Domestic abuse-related death · Domestic homicide · Domestic violence fatality review · Domestic homicide review · LGBTQ+

There is a growing body of evidence about the prevalence and impact of, and agency responses to, domestic abuse in Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual, Trans and Queer (LGBTQ+) relationships (McGregor, 2023). An essential feature of this work has been to challenge cis heteronormative approaches that have led LGBTQ+ people’s experiences to be unrecognized or marginalized, and also to explicate what might be the same and different in terms of both experience and help seeking (Donovan & Hester, 2015). Alongside this increasing understanding of domestic abuse in LGBTQ+ communities generally, there has long been a recognition that intimate partner abuse can end in fatality (Island & Letellier, 1991; Renzetti, 1992). Indeed, overall, victims from gender and sexual minorities are likely at the same level of risk as their cisgender counterparts (Messinger, 2017). However, there are significant differences *within* LGBTQ+ communities, the recognition of which echoes more general calls to avoid assumed homogeneity (McGregor, 2023). For

example, while the picture for trans victims is still developing (Sherman et al., 2024), intimate partner homicide appears to be highest amongst gay men (Mize & Shackelford, 2008). In contrast, although fatal violence can occur in women’s same sex relationships (Glass et al., 2004), there is a need to understand better the profile of killings of lesbian and bisexual women, including where a male perpetrator may be responsible (Anderson et al., 2023). Taken together, along with other kinds of domestic abuse-related deaths, such as those at the hands of family members or deaths by suicide, LGBTQ+ intimate partner homicide remains under-researched (Messing et al., 2022).

To some extent, this evidence gap reflects the burden of domestic abuse, meaning the focus of activists, researchers and policymakers has primarily been on the experience of cis heterosexual women at the hands of cis heterosexual men. Additionally, there are specific challenges to better understanding LGBTQ+ domestic abuse-related deaths, not least because administrative data – including case records but also national statistics – often fail to identify or report on the experience of gender and sexual minorities (Cullen et al., 2021). Illustrating these two points, in England and Wales, of the 352 people killed by a former/current partner or family member from April 2021 to March 2024, only

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five were killed by a former/current same-sex partner, all of whom were men in same-sex relationships (Office for National Statistics [ONS], Ien et al., 2025). However, this data only disaggregates homicides by sex and relationship type, meaning it is not possible to identify all LGBTQ+ deaths in this context (Miles et al., 2025).

This gap is troubling because examining domestic abuse-related deaths is essential to better understand precursors (including victim experiences and enablers/barriers to help and support) and pathways to these tragedies, for LGBTQ+ people in their own right and vis-à-vis their heterosexual/cisgender peers (Rossiter et al., 2020). This is not simply about building a better picture of these deaths, as important as that task is. Critically, such an examination is also an opportunity to identify learning and consider what might help improve responses to LGBTQ+ victim/survivors. Such a task is essential given LGBTQ+ victim/survivors face enduring challenges, both in terms of recognition by self or others in the public story of domestic abuse (Donovan & Hester, 2015) and in accessing and the quality of agency responses (Galop, 2023).

One way to address this evidence gap could be through Domestic Violence Fatality Review (DVFR), which is a mechanism for examining and learning from domestic abuse-related deaths. However, DVFRs face a range of barriers to the inclusion of LGBTQ+ domestic abuse-related deaths (Fairbairn et al., 2017). In response, this commentary considers how DVFRs can better engage with LGBTQ+ domestic abuse-related deaths, drawing on my perspective as a practitioner (who has led DVFRs in England and Wales) and as a researcher (whose work is primarily concerned with domestic abuse-related deaths and death review). I first discuss DVFRs, with a specific focus on England and Wales. Then, I consider if and how DVFRs can respond to LGBTQ+ domestic abuse-related deaths, including how LGBTQ+ lives can be rendered invisible by these mechanisms if they are *misrecognized or minoritized*. In contrast, I argue for the importance of working to ensure LGBTQ+ lives are *preserved* within DVFR systems. I conclude by considering the implications for practice and policy, as well as the methodological implications for research using DVFRs.

Domestic Violence Fatality Review

Initially developed in the United States, DVFR systems first spread primarily to English-speaking countries such as Australia, Canada, England and Wales, and New Zealand (Dawson, 2017), and have since been established in other countries as well, with calls for further expansion (UNODC, 2023). DVFR systems vary considerably, but they generally

consider domestic abuse-related deaths – usually intimate partner homicides, often adult family homicides, and sometimes other cases like deaths by suicide (Bugeja et al., 2015) – and examine these cases to generate case profiles, learning, and recommendations for practice, policy and systems change (Dawson, 2021; Websdale, 2022). To do so, in varying ways and to different degrees, DVFRs usually bring together a range of actors, including state and non-governmental agencies, and sometimes family and wider communities.

Domestic Homicide Reviews in England and Wales

In England and Wales, the DVFR system is known as Domestic Homicide Review (DHR).¹ DHRs were established under s.9 of the *Domestic Violence, Crime and Victims Act* 2004, implemented in 2011, and their conduct is governed by statutory guidance (most recently: Home Office, 2016). When a domestic abuse-related death is identified – including killings by intimate partners and adult family homicides, as well as deaths by suicide – a DHR should be commissioned at a local level by the responsible partnership body. To conduct a DHR, an independent chair leads a multi-agency review panel – including representatives from statutory organizations (e.g., the police and other criminal justice agencies, health providers, and local authorities) and others (e.g., domestic abuse and other specialists) – and should also engage with testimonial networks too (e.g., family but also friends, neighbors, and colleagues). By bringing these stakeholders into dialogue, a picture of the case circumstances is built, and, from this, findings are generated (including learning and recommendations for practice, policy, and systems change). Ultimately, for each case, a report is produced, usually anonymized, and then usually published. For a more detailed overview, see Rowlands (2025). To date, most research has focused on DHR findings, including the learning and recommendations derived from them, although no study has specifically examined LGBTQ+ deaths and sexual orientation and gender identity are often unreported (e.g. Chantler et al., 2020; Chopra et al., 2022). Additionally, there has been increasing recognition of the complex operational, discursive, and symbolic practices that shape the conduct of, and the findings from, DHRs and DVFRs more generally (Cook et al., 2023). Thus, in England and Wales, it has been recognized that the DHR process is challenging, with the potential for contestation and conflict between the independent chair, the review panel, and family, as well as questions around the

¹ Being renamed as Domestic Abuse Related Death Reviews (DARDRs). Wales has also developed a system known as the Single Unified Safeguarding Review (SUSR) model, which brings together DHRs with other forms of review involving deat

quality of the findings and the impact of any recommendations (Haines-Delmont et al., 2022). Of particular note for any discussion of minoritized communities is the requirement in the statutory guidance that DHRs should address matters of “equality and diversity” (Home Office, 2016, p. 36) – which, in the UK and for LGBTQ+ victims, means considering the protected characteristics of gender reassignment, sex, and/or sexual orientation as defined in the *Equality Act* 2010. However, in practice, a key concern is that DHRs may fail to do so adequately. For example, Gunby et al. (2025) analyzed how gender and other intersectional dynamics are addressed in DHRs, arguing for the importance of an intersectional perspective to understand how experiences of violence and abuse are structured by oppression and privilege as a result of the convergence of social identities (Collins & Bilge, 2020; Crenshaw, 1991). They concluded that, although some DHRs evidenced good practices by, for example, explicitly describing their approach to intersectionality, most did not. Even more problematically, Gunby et al. identified how DHRs may not engage with, or misunderstand, victims’ situated experiences. Indeed, at worst, DHRs may perpetuate stereotypes about a given community (Chantler et al., 2022). Having considered what is known about domestic abuse-related deaths in LGBTQ+ communities, and introduced DVFR/DHR, I now turn to the extent to which LGBTQ+ lives can be rendered (in)visible by these mechanisms. In doing so, I draw on my practitioner–researcher perspective, primarily informed by my experience of chairing two reviews – the first into the killing of a trans woman (referred to by the pseudonym ‘Jimena’) (Rowlands, 2019), and the second into the death by suicide of a gay man (referred to by the pseudonym ‘Patrick’) (Rowlands, 2023a) – and also a scoping study of nine DHRs published between 2012 and 2017 and involving LGBTQ+ people (Rowlands, 2023b). My focus is on identifying, including knowledge and expertise about, and representing the lives of LGBTQ+ people, as well as on the methodological implications for research.

Identifying LGBT+ Domestic Abuse-Related Deaths

An issue for any DVFR system is what deaths to include, with this often revolving around whether all or only some types of domestic abuse-related deaths should be in scope (i.e. the inclusion of intimate, familial and/or other types of deaths somehow connected to domestic abuse) (Fairbairn et al., 2017). However, for LGBTQ+ victims, their deaths may not be identified at all (Messinger, 2017). Specifically, LGBTQ+ victims may be unseen if someone had not felt able or confident to disclose their identity and/or

relationship, administrative data cannot capture the same, or the nature of the relationship was unclear (Rossiter et al., 2020). The importance of relational status was evident in the scoping study, where three of the nine DHRs included intimate relationships where the relationship status was unclear (although, evidently, in these cases, that had not prevented a DHR). However, sometimes a lack of recognition of the potential differences in the profile of LGBTQ+ domestic abuse-related deaths can also preclude consideration. To illustrate this, consider the murder of Cassie Hayes in January 2018 by the ex-male partner of her girlfriend (Laura Williams). Before the killing, threats had been made to Williams by her ex-partner, who had also threatened to kill himself and Hayes (BBC News, 2018). However, after the killing of Hayes, the local partnership did not commission a DHR because “the case did not fit the criteria” (personal communication, March 23, 2019). Technically, the decision was consistent with the statutory guidance, as Hayes and the perpetrator did not have an intimate relationship. Yet Hayes was only targeted because she was in a relationship with Williams. Such a decision may have also been made in a scenario involving a new male partner, as such victims – who can be referred to as corollary victims, as they are not the intimate partner themselves (Smith et al., 2014) – are not explicitly in the scope of DHRs. Nonetheless, given the evidence about (fatal) violence by former male partners towards lesbian, gay and bi women (Herek et al., 2002; Rose, 2003), this failure to recognize that connection and thus Hayes as a corollary victim is striking. Moreover, despite not being formally within scope, on the basis of its potential contribution to the understanding of domestic abuse, the local partnership could have made a decision to conduct a review (given other local partnerships have made decisions to deviate from statutory guidance in the past, see Payton et al., 2017). Understanding why and how some deaths are included or not in DVFR systems is important, not least because exclusions affect our ability to learn from fatal violence and so inform preventative efforts, including the recognition of queer relationships in these efforts (Miles et al., 2025).

Including LGBTQ* Knowledge and Expertise

A key aspect of any DVFR system is the ambition to, in examining cases, “tap the talents” of a range of stakeholders (Websdale, 2022, p. 18) so that each can bring information about any contact their agency had and/or share their disciplinary and/or sector expertise. Although there are challenges in bringing stakeholders together, if achieved, this enables a fuller understanding of a victim’s experiences and, in turn, widens the lens of the potential learning and

recommendations that can be generated (Rowlands, 2025). This ambition is reflected in DHRs in England and Wales too, with review panels required to be “sufficiently configured to bring relevant expertise in relation to the particular circumstances of the case” (Home Office, 2016, p. 11). For DHRs into the killing or death of a minoritized victim, such a configuration should include specialist knowledge and expertise. This inclusion is argued as being important as it means the findings generated are more likely to take account of the specific issues that minoritized victims can face by, for example, interrogating questions of access to or confidence in services (Chantler et al., 2022). Such specialist knowledge and expertise is most appropriately provided by led-by-and-for services which are “services that are governed, managed and staffed by the same community they are providing services for” (Kumar, 2019, p. 180). Similarly, the Domestic Abuse Commissioner (DAC) for England and Wales has described such services as “designed and delivered by and for people who are minoritised’ and, critically, “rooted in the communities they serve” (Domestic Abuse Commissioner, 2022, p. 64). Illustratively, in the DHRs I have chaired, I worked with the local areas to ensure the inclusion of specialist knowledge and expertise. In Jimena’s case, we were fortunate that a specialist LGBTQ+ domestic abuse service operated locally and could join the review panel (along with, as the victim was a Mexican national, a service that worked with Latin American communities). In contrast, in Patrick’s case, the local area did not have a specialist LGBTQ+ domestic abuse service, although it was possible to access support from an LGBTQ+ community organization. Such variability is common, and, in fact, in many LGBTQ+ DHRs, specialist knowledge and expertise may not be included at all. Illustratively, in the scoping study, only three DHRs included an LGBTQ+ agency on the review panel (of which only one was a domestic abuse specialist). Notably, however, this absence speaks to a broader structural issue: there is a lack of LGBTQ+ domestic abuse provision across England and Wales (Galop, 2023), with LGBTQ+ victims often unable to access such specialism despite a preference for it (Domestic Abuse Commissioner, 2022).

Representing the Lives of LGBTQ+ People

Ultimately, any DVFR system is necessarily engaged in a process of extracting learning from killings or deaths, an endeavor which is fraught with methodological and ethical challenges (Cook et al., 2023; Rowlands, 2025). Here, there are specific issues for LGBTQ+ victims, which may also be linked to the lack of specialist knowledge and expertise discussed above. As noted earlier, there has been growing

recognition that DHRs must take an intersectional perspective, both to improve the quality of learning and recommendations and to avoid perpetuating stereotypes about minoritized communities (Chantler et al., 2022; Gunby et al., 2025). One enabler of such a perspective is, as noted above, the inclusion of specialist knowledge and expertise from led-by-and-for specialist services, who – as I recognized in DHRs I have chaired – can be critical in helping achieve an intersectional perspective. As necessary, drawing on academic research or best practice guidance can also assist in this endeavor. Taken together, these sources can be used to try to understand how victims and/or agencies did or might make sense of or respond to violence and abuse, as well as to interrogate the extent of the local partnership’s knowledge about, and strategic response to, domestic abuse in LGBTQ+ communities. However, a DHR is premised on the assumption that, to “understand the victim’s reality” it is necessary to “articulate the life through the eyes of the victim” (Home Office, 2016, p. 7). This speaks to the effort to take an intersectional approach too, as it is necessary to try and come alongside a victim and imagine how they might have understood their experiences and options both as individuals but also in a wider relational, community and societal context (Rowlands, 2025). Yet, in the scoping study many DHRs took a instrumental, narrow approach. Frequently, LGBTQ+ identities were primarily referenced in the context of relationship status and were otherwise oblique, with the focus instead on individuals, with little exploration of the significance and/or impact of someone’s identity and the wider relational, community, or societal context, including potential barriers to help-seeking. As a result, the risk is that, in a DHR, an LGBTQ+ victim’s life might be inadequately represented. To conceptualize this, we can draw on a framework from translation studies, initially proposed by Démont and later adapted by Iturregui-Gallardo (2023). This framework argues that, in translating a text, one might “hide or simplify the queer” due to *misrecognition or minoritization*. In contrast, one might successfully “transfer the queer”, thus *preserving* it (p.174). Preservation in this use means the recognition and transference of the LGBTQ+ experience, which, in the original framework, relates to the translator’s success in capturing the author’s intent, e.g., in terms of sex and desire. In the context of a DHR, I take this framework to be concerned with how fully an LGBTQ+ person’s life is understood, insofar as that is possible post-death, and then described. I illustrate this framework as applied to the representation of LGBTQ+ lives in DHRs in Fig. 1. In the first example, Mr. D was a bisexual man who died by suicide and had, at the time, been in a relationship with a woman. However, while the DHR did touch on his sexual orientation, this was *misrecognized* as something that had a binary and temporality-based status, with a distinction being made

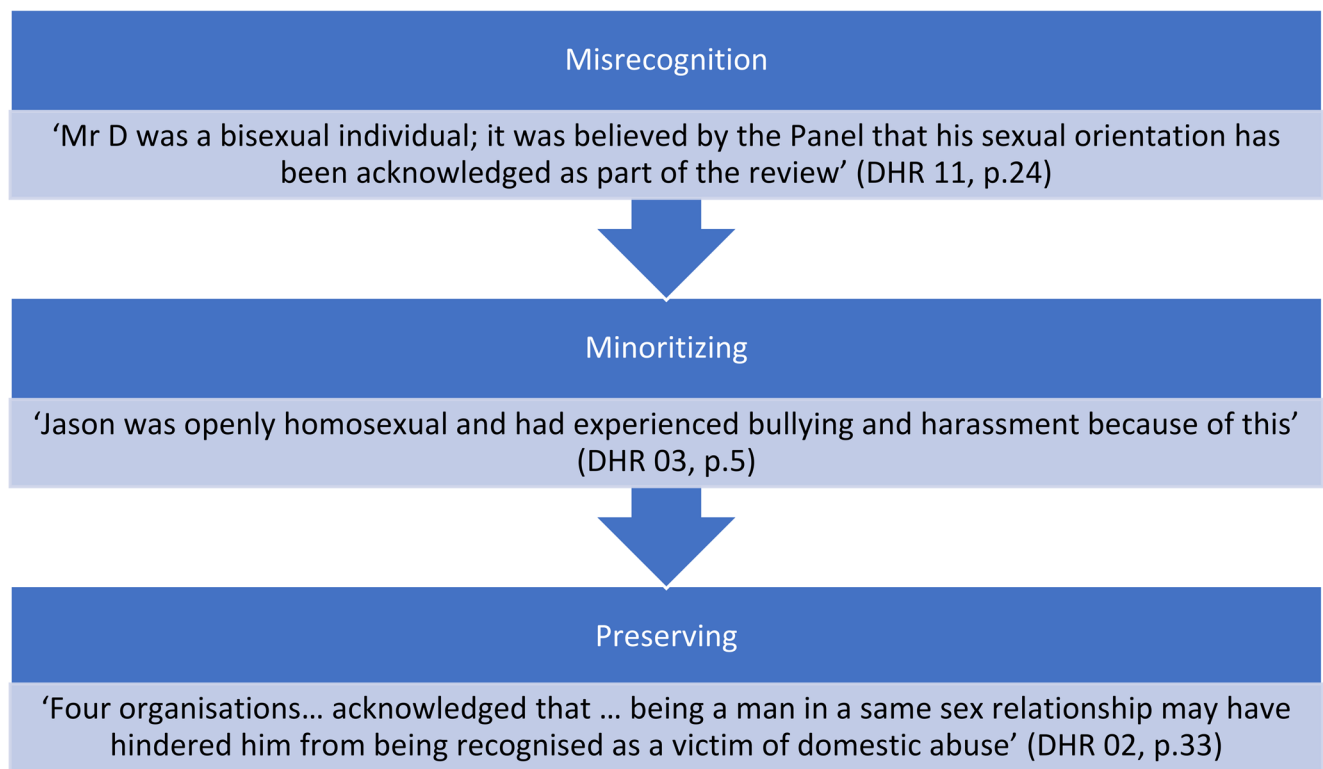


Fig. 1 Representing the Queer. Note: This figure demonstrates the application of the framework initially proposed by Démont and later adapted by Iturregui-Gallardo (2023)

between his previous relationship with a man and his more recent relationship with a woman. In the second example, Jason was referred to as “openly homosexual”, itself an outdated, medicalized terminology, with the accompanying narrative *minoritizing* his experience of bullying and harassment by focusing on his openness about his sexual orientation rather than recognizing the structural context of homophobia. In contrast, in a third example, efforts to *preserve* the queer meant that the DHR included considerations of the lived experience of gay men and explicitly recognized that being an LGBTQ+ victim may have negatively shaped help-seeking.

Explained in another way, this is about ensuring that deaths count (Walklate et al., 2020), not solely in the narrower sense of tabulation, but also through meaningful efforts to understand the experiences of those affected. Moreover, considering the representation of LGBTQ+ lives not only centers those who have been killed or died, but it also helps generate more widely framed learning that, in turn, informs the recommendations generated. Within a DHR that means, having sought to orientate to a victim by trying to understand their lived experience as structurally situated, using this in turn to interrogate the adequacy of practice, policy and system responses. For LGBTQ+ victims, that could include exploring questions for local agencies and the wider partnership such as:

- Is there a good understanding of the size and needs of the local LGBTQ+ population? As all the evidence tells us that reporting is often low and/or often to providers that differ to their cis heterosexual counterparts, what is known about what is and is not working for LGBTQ+ victim/survivors?
- Are efforts being made to reach out to and engage with LGBTQ+ victim/survivors in a substantive way, including concrete actions to consult with local LGBTQ+ communities about how to identify and address need?
- Are pro-active steps being taken to raise awareness of LGBTQ+ domestic abuse, with inclusively designed and promoted publicity and awareness-raising campaigns?
- Are pathways to help and support robust and can local agencies meet the needs of LGBTQ+ victim/survivors (including in terms of policy and procedure, as well as ensuring staff have the appropriate skills and knowledge to respond to LGBTQ+ people)?
- How are agencies working together to better respond to the needs of LGBTQ+ victim/survivors? This could be through reciprocal training swaps, ensuring there are robust referral pathways, or making sure the development of publicity and awareness-raising campaigns takes account of LGBTQ+ victim/survivors.
- Has the local partnership thought about how to develop services? For example, is there an opportunity to

develop a business case for a specialist LGBTQ+ service, ideally one that is co-produced with and ultimately led by and for LGBTQ+ communities?

Implications for Research, Policy and/or Practice

The considerations identified in this commentary – about the identification of LGBTQ+ domestic abuse-related deaths, the inclusion of specialist expertise and knowledge, and representations of LGBTQ+ victims' lives – have important implications for practice and policy for DHRs in England and Wales and DVFR systems more generally. First, they highlight the importance of reflecting on how DVFR systems are designed and operate, including the potential for the inclusion and exclusion of LGBT+ lives. Second, inclusion in this context is not simply a technical question of identifying LGBTQ+ domestic abuse-related death. Instead, inclusion is about ensuring that DVFR systems can engage with the lived experience of gender and sexual minorities by considering both individual experiences and also taking an intersectional perspective that recognizes the importance of relational, community and societal factors too. Drawing on a conceptualization of how LGBTQ+ lives can be misrecognized, minoritized, or preserved is one way of bringing academic knowledge to bear on the operation of DVFR systems. Both these issues speak to the broader practice, policy, and research landscape, where there is concern about what is required to deliver and sustain effective DVFR systems, including the training and support for those involved and questions of impact (Rowlands, 2025). The discussion here also has methodological implications for researchers using DVFR systems' outputs. As Guyan (2022) has argued, we need to engage with systems that produce data critically, recognizing both the tensions and risks within them, as well as the prospects of using them and the data they produce to positively represent and lead to change in the lives of LGBTQ+ people. For DVFRs, that means it is essential that researchers engage critically with these mechanisms, including considering how they may make (in)visible the experience of LGBT+ people. In addition to the academic work already cited here (Chantler et al., 2022; Gunby et al., 2025), there is also a small but growing body of work produced by non-governmental organizations which has interrogated the practices of review in relation to victims from particular communities or with specific experiences (e.g. for Black and minorities women, see Centre for Women's Justice [CWJ] and Imkaan, (2023), and victims in the sex industry, see Hasham and Thorlby (2023). As Rowlands and Bracewell (2022) have described, a DHR report is the result of layers of interpretation, from if and how contact is

recorded with agencies in the first instance, to how issues are explored in a review panel, to the report itself and how this is analyzed by researchers. It is thus essential to engage critically with DHR reports as contingent products, including reflecting on the extent of efforts to include LGBTQ+ knowledge and expertise and represent LGBTQ+ lives.

Finally, this also highlights the role of cross-national research. Specifically, despite differences across country contexts, there will be considerable opportunities in bringing together learning from cases involving minoritized communities, as much as for the learning about how to approach work with these communities as for what is learnt about the killings and deaths themselves (Jaffe et al., 2020).

Conclusion

This commentary has explored how a mechanism for examining domestic abuse-related deaths can work to make LGBTQ+ lives (in)visible. While the discussion here relates primarily to LGBTQ+ victims, it speaks to the broader literature that has identified the steps that need to be taken to ensure that DVFR systems are an appropriate, meaningful and effective response to domestic abuse-related deaths. In seeking to honor those who are killed or who die, this work is about centering individual LGBT+ victims. However, by generating learning and recommendations about LGBTQ+ domestic abuse-related deaths, DVFRs can also shape the public story. As a result, this work is also about ensuring the expansion of the public story beyond a cis heteronormative horizon to recognize LGBTQ+ lives too.

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